

the Reckoner
of Marc Garneau C.I.
DECEMBER 2020

SORRY
— WE ARE —
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ADVER- TISING SPACE



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Smiling Eyes

by JESSICA XIONG

Quarantine has been hard for many of us. During a time when the city is in lockdown again, finding a reason to smile each day may be tough. Although we have to wear a mask that hides half our face, the eyes provide a window for us to express our emotions. This photo collage project was created to highlight the way our eyes sparkle when we smile, with the hopes that seeing this will make you, the reader, find your reason to smile today. ■

Photographs: Allan Li, Amy Jia, Angela Xu, Evelyn Jiang, Jessica Xiong



NEWS BOARD

A board to keep the student body informed about their school and local community.



Chatting with Ms. Chang

by RENA LIU

This year, Marc Garneau C.I. welcomed three new vice principals: Ms. Chang, Ms. Sawh, and Ms. Sutherns. For this edition, Rena Liu interviewed vice principal Ms. Chang, who is the administrator for grade nine students.

Q: What was your career path to becoming vice principal? Were there any obstacles or difficult decisions you had to make?

A: I guess the short answer to this question is that my path was actually quite the journey, one that is still continuing. When I look back, it all seems pretty clear and I can see how things lined up, but at the time, I assure you, it did not seem clear at all!

I really did not know what I wanted to do as a career, but it seemed that I enjoyed every job I had that involved working with kids. When I graduated from the University of Toronto, I landed a job with the Ontario Science Centre—I was one of the people that did Science demonstrations and made people's hair stand up! It was an amazing job that I loved and then I knew for sure that I wanted to be a teacher.

The issue was that everyone around me was saying that there were no jobs and that there were very limited spots for teacher training programs. I decided to apply to teacher's college regardless of the dire prospects. However, I must tell you that I was not accepted. I was very disappointed by this news, but in hindsight, this was perhaps the best thing that could have happened.

A few days after the rejection letter I was surprised by an invitation to join a teacher apprenticeship program with the North York Board of Education. I was paid to apprentice with a teacher and work alongside them in a local school. In addition, when I successful-

ly completed the program, I would be guaranteed a spot at a Teacher's College the following year. So that is exactly what I did, and I learned so much! I have always felt that not getting accepted to Teacher's College that year was the best thing that ever happened to me!

I have been teaching for twenty-four years now and I have enjoyed every role in education that I have had the privilege of holding. The best part is that I am still on a learning journey and every day I enjoy coming to school and being a part of this community.

Q: What drew you to become the Grade 9 vice principal? What do you love most about being the Grade 9 vice principal?

A: Great question! I wanted to be the Grade 9 vice principal because it is my first year at MGCI and I felt that I would have something in common with our grade nine students who are also new to MGCI. I know that Grade 9 is a very important year as it is the first year where students begin earning credits towards their Ontario Secondary School Diploma. I also know that high school offers many new opportunities for students in Grade 9 to develop their leadership skills and explore new interests. It is full of new challenges and opportunities. I want to be sure that our MGCI Grade 9 students feel supported and challenged in order to really embrace these new opportunities. I also knew that although I wanted to focus on Grade 9 students, I am part of an amazing administration and guidance team that supports all of our MGCI students. Next year, the plan will be that I move with my Grade 9 students to Grade 10, so I am looking forward to getting to know each and every one of you.

Q: What are your favourite hobbies and what items do you still have to cross off your bucket list? Also, are there any activities or hobbies that you have picked up during COVID-19?

A: I am a very proud mom to three beautiful daughters, so I find my life outside of school to be very busy. When I do make time for myself, I really like to find a sunny spot and get lost in a good book. As well, I recently started taking a yoga class, but with COVID my class was can-



Photograph: Helen Lin

celled and I have switched to a yoga app. I miss the class—I am more accountable when I am in an in-person class. I have always been fascinated with helicopters and so if anything is on my bucket list, it is learning to fly a helicopter!

During COVID-19, I have missed going to the movies, especially the theatres with the reclining seats. However, in quarantine my family and I watched a lot of television on Netflix as a substitute. I have always loved sci-fi movies and TV shows, so some of my favourites are Stranger Things and The Mandalorian as well as all of the Star Trek and Star Wars movies. I also enjoy getting outside and going for a walk. I find this helps keep me active and cancel out all the muffins and cookies regularly baked by my family.

Q: What message would you want to give to students during these challenging times?

A: You are not alone. All of us have been impacted by COVID-19. I know that I am very glad to be back at school and connecting with students and colleagues, but I also know that to do this safely, we have all had to make changes and follow safety protocols. I know that the efforts we have made and continue to make do make a difference. We all need to do our part. Be sure to show kindness to others—even in small ways. Taking a moment to smile at someone, even with a mask on, makes a difference. Sending a text to a friend to check in on them shows you care. If you are struggling or know someone who is, reach out for help. Speak to a caring adult—a teacher, a guidance counsellor, or your vice principal. We care about you and are here to help. Let's be sure to support each other and continue to build a caring and supportive MGCI community. ■

Pandemic Perspectives: The Effects of COVID-19 on MGCI

by ZAHRA AHMED and UROOBA SHAIKH

Walking into Marc Garneau Collegiate during a school day now looks very different than it did last year. From once crowded hallways to now empty ones, hugs in the hallways to "hands to yourself", precautionary measures against COVID-19 have significantly impacted the daily lives of everyone at MGCI.

Before entering the school, each person must complete a health screening consisting of a series of questions relating to showing signs and symptoms of COVID-19. On school property, masks must be worn at all times and there are designated stairwells for entry and exit on each floor. Arrows have been placed in hallways to reinforce social distancing and direct students as they enter and exit the building.

In-person classes take place from 8:45 am to 12:30 pm with short breaks in between and each classroom contains about fifteen students seated two meters apart. For washroom breaks, teachers must call a hall monitor to escort the student to the washroom and only two students are allowed inside at a time. Water fountains are unavailable, although students have access to a water bottle refill station.

Students continuing with hybrid models attend two to three in-school classes each week, while continuing the rest of the course through asynchronous and virtual learning periods. To further limit contact between students and teachers, regular class sizes have been split into cohorts A and B, each attending school on different days.

Grade 10 student Ukram Gul said, "The quadmester so far is hard to balance, since both classes are moving so fast. And even more challenging when you have math and science together." Kainat Fatima, a Grade 10 student, added, "I do think that quadmasters were helpful in the sense that I have learned how to study better independently and juggle two difficult courses together."

Students also had the option to attend virtual school, where they were placed in classes with other

students in the similar ward. Their course schedule consists of two hours of synchronous learning and half an hour of independent learning per day for each class.

Nowrin Noor, Grade 11, said "The biggest challenge with virtual school is it goes way faster than normal school, and if you miss out on something, it's hard to catch up. There's also nothing to regulate your schedule so the week just feels like a blob of sleeping and



Photograph: Bill Yan

studying." She added, "To stay connected, I try to communicate with teachers as much as possible. I also join clubs and programs like the AIS program at UofT and the Arts Council of MGCI."

Marc Garneau CI has been labelled as an outbreak school, with eleven confirmed cases of COVID-19 as of 22 November 2020. Thirteen classes have been required to self isolate to prevent the tentative spread.

Talha Jogiat, a Grade 10 student who was required to self-isolate along with his class, said, "While self isolating for the last few days, it helped me rebuild my bond with my sister as it made us spend a lot of time together, so I'm very grateful for that." However, his experience with virtual school was different. "Personally, I have a very short attention span, and it becomes difficult to learn at home due to the fact that there is no physical presence of a teacher."

In addition to students, teachers have also been significantly

impacted by the changes. Physical Education Teacher Ms. Manjra described the modifications in her teaching. "It's very uncomfortable to wear a mask during physical education because of the sweat, but I also can't read the student's faces. I have no idea how they feel, how they are doing, if they are enjoying themselves and that leaves me frustrated at times. It has been challenging to come up with activities that are engaging and socially distant."

A few weeks ago, the City of Toronto announced the closure of all fitness centres, including the one at MGCI, which means that phys. ed. classes have been restricted to the east and west sides of the gym and classrooms.

"We've had to get even more creative with the way we had to teach our classes given the facilities we had available. I try to take my classes outside whenever I can. Since March we've been advised to stay inside, so the fitness levels aren't the same as it would be, if it were any other year. It has been an excellent opportunity to incorporate yoga, mindfulness and valley walks with the extra time," added Ms. Manjra.

Along with the physical precautions being taken inside the school, another significant change for both teachers and students has been the hour and fifteen minute virtual period every day. This has been done to reduce the number of people present in the school and limit person-to-person contact.

When asked about virtual teaching, Ms. Manjra said, "Lessons and classes which are usually group and discussion based have been more challenging to do online, as students have been less comfortable to share their thoughts and opinions behind the screen. Students have also kept their cameras off, as they don't feel comfortable putting them on. As a teacher teaching a class, it is easy to lose momentum, when I'm staring at a screen and I can't see any of my students. I feel teaching is a shared experience, you pick up on the energy of your students, they drive you and ener-

gize you. This exchange is compromised virtually.”

Many students recall the feelings of excitement and nervousness during their first year at Marc Garneau. However, for freshmen this year, the sentiment is slightly different. Adjusting to a new school can be quite a challenge in itself, and for Grade 9 students this year, it has become even more difficult with all the changes caused by the pandemic.

Grade 9 student Umamah Najam said, “Coming to a new school is a completely different experience. We went from being the oldest in middle school to being the youngest in high school, and that’s sort of intimidating. Usually, we would get a tour around the school and be able to meet our teachers and peers properly, which would have made us more comfortable. It’s also a big jump because learning is very different as well. Teachers are worried about not being able to finish units on time and that means that the work is very crammed.”

Hadia Kabli, another Grade 9 student, added, “I was really looking forward to all the events and field trips that I had heard about. Coming to high school sounded like it would be very fun, but now with the social distancing rules, all of that is pretty much impossible. It’s hard to even meet new people and spend time with your friends.”

MGCI’s Student Activity Council (SAC) has been trying to create a sense of community within the school despite the circumstances, which has always been a significant part of their role. The sudden lockdown had not allowed for SAC reelections, so last year’s council is still in office.

SAC Interim Vice President Ryan Chang said, “Personally, the main problem is school spirit, this was hard to get popular even without COVID, so we are really trying to think of ways to engage students. Normally we’d have pep rallies, a Grade 9 BBQ, dances, and talent shows, but all of that isn’t logistically possible anymore.”

So far, SAC has held virtual spirit activities with the main event being a tournament of the popular game “Among Us.” However, the fact that these events are online means that they garner fewer participants. The goal is to promote spirit and con-

nectivity within the school community as much as possible, even while keeping distance. Other than spirit events, SAC has been keeping up with administrative tasks such as setting up clubs registration and acting as the liaison between students and staff.

“Overall, I feel like we’re doing the best we can. It’s hard to communicate with our staff advisors, the entire [SAC] team, and especially the office online since everyone’s still trying to adapt while having other commitments at home,” added Ryan.

Grade 12 students in their final year of high school have also been impacted greatly by the pandemic. In pre-pandemic times, students would have been able to attend information sessions and visit col-



Photograph: Bill Yan

leges and universities to get a better understanding of what their post-secondary experience might look like. Now, however, all information must be obtained through virtual tours and sessions.

“It’s kind of hard to make decisions about your future based on zoom calls”, said Grade 12 student Rana Balabel.

“Since it’s our final year, I think a lot of us were looking forward to events such as prom and, of course, graduation. It’s sort of sad that our last year of high school, where memories are usually made, is being spent half at home, with no celebration and limited interaction,” added Labibah Salim, another senior.

Along with Grade 12 students, their guidance counselors have also been dealing with many changes as they try to guide those in their final year. Post-secondary information

sessions are now being held exclusively online, and all questions or concerns must be addressed through email.

“I feel that the communication aspect has become somewhat difficult,” said Grade 12 Counselor Ms. McIsaac. “We get many requests from students in a single day, and it takes a lot of going back and forth before issues can actually be resolved. However, I think it’s also good that students learn to communicate this way now because they’ll probably have to do more of it in university. Important events such as post-secondary information sessions have also gone completely virtual, and I think another challenge with this is getting word out to students. We have a guidance Google Classroom and we do our best to post up-to-date information frequently, but students don’t always check. It’s difficult to communicate this way, but we’re doing our best to help students in the ways we can.”

While MGCI is a new world compared to last year, one piece of familiarity is the snack program. In pre-pandemic times, snack bins would be placed outside stairwells on the first floor at the start of the second period for students to pick up. Now, trays of healthy snacks are set up outside door 7 for students to grab on their way home. Staff members are stationed nearby with bottles of hand sanitizer in hand, and students are required to sanitize their hands before touching any of the food items.

Vice Principal Mr. Haid reflected on the current situation. “I am impressed with peoples’ resilience. I am impressed by the flexibility and adaptability of students and teachers. Though I miss the routine and predictability of pre-COVID times, I acknowledge that good can come from times of struggle and challenge. I hope that we take this knowledge and work to ensure that we come out of this challenge with a greater sense of community, shared humanity and care for those around us.” The MGCI community has been impacted by COVID-19 in many ways. While students and staff are facing unprecedented challenges, the school community as a whole is doing its best to stay connected and limit the spread of the virus. ■



Fun with French at the MGCI French Club

by STEPHIE LIU

The Marc Garneau CI French Club was founded in 2018 with the purpose of fostering interest in French language and culture outside of the classroom. This year, despite being relocated virtually to Discord, the French Club continues to offer an environment where students can enrich their knowledge of the language through a variety of different activities.

The French Club has grown to include over twenty-five members with two executive members, one vice president, and two co-presidents, Andrew Wu and Rena Liu.

When asked about the French Club’s goals for this year, co-president Andrew Wu said, “MGCI French Club strives to give students a fun and welcoming environment to interact with each other in French. We also plan to offer a variety of activities for students to familiarize themselves with French culture and hone their French skills.” Andrew added, “We are always on the lookout for new activities that students can engage in. This year, in particular, we are aiming to add volunteer work and tutoring to the list of our club’s activities.”

As of 5 November 2020, meetings for the French Club occur every Friday at 4:00 PM through the use of a Discord voice channel, but the meeting

time may change to accommodate more members. The executive members and presidents usually start the meetings by holding a small presentation to introduce some new French vocabulary for the “activity of the day” which takes place after the presentation. Club members are encouraged to speak in French throughout the meeting and to participate in weekly activities ranging from Escape Rooms to Among Us.

The French Club also hosts special events for holidays, such as a Halloween-themed meeting which took place on 30 October 2020. The French vocabulary words covered for this meeting were all related to the subject of Halloween, and the activity for the week was a spooky virtual escape room. Going forward, co-president Rena Liu said she believes that the French Club will continue to host meetings for special occasions, such as Remembrance Day and Christmas, and she hopes to introduce virtual tours of well-known Francophone locations using Google Maps.

Many students see the French

Club as an educational and enjoyable extracurricular, where they can improve their French skills as well as interact with other students. Olivia Huang, a new member to the club, commented, “I decided to join French Club because French has been such a big aspect of my life since I was young as I went to a French Immersion school. I’m not taking any French courses until the last semester and this would be a great way to meet others interested in French and keep speaking and listening to French.”

In response to the success of the virtual French Club meetings, Andrew Wu said, “We are very pleased that numerous students have shown interest in practicing and improving their French skills. We will continue to improve the quality of our virtual meetings.”

Students interested in joining the MGCI French Club this year are welcome to join the public Facebook group and Discord channel to participate in the weekly meetings. ■

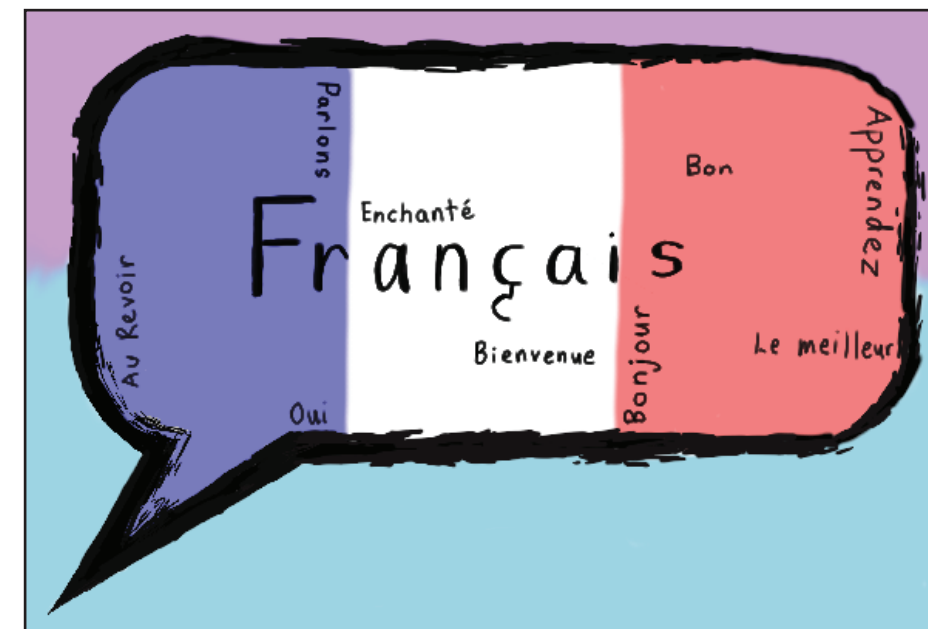


Illustration: Lauren Liu

Petition Alleges Proposed Flemingdon Park Development Failed to Consult Community

by JACQUELINE HUO

On 9 November 2020, university students Sahar and Salwa Abdalla created a petition titled “SAVE FLEMINGDON PARK” which calls for a rejection of a development proposal for 25 St. Dennis Drive, a property located just over a kilometre away from MGCI. Preston Group, the company that owns the property, first proposed the development in December 2015.

Both young women are residents of Flemingdon Park and have lived in the community since early childhood. Sahar won the 2017 TD Scholarship for Community Leadership for volunteering with a local organization that offers assistance with French homework.

City Council staff held a community consultation meeting on 18 May 2016 with fifty members of the public in attendance [1]. However, according to Sahar, many community members were not notified. She said, “We heard rumours, and people were talking about it. But my family, we know that the city has to send notices, we know that they have to inform residents. We thought ‘oh they’re going to hold a consultation sometime,’ but we never actually got notice of that consultation. So while we were aware that some-



Illustration: Julia Shen

thing was going on we just thought that [since] we’re within the area where construction is going to be occurring, of course they would notify us and tell us where we can participate.”

She also mentioned that if residents did receive notices, they were only available in English. In Flemingdon Park, 50% of residents speak a language other than English at home [2]. While they may still be fluent or have some level of comprehension, there is a significant portion of the population who were not properly notified and unable to attend the consultation meeting to voice their opinions.

In November 2017, Toronto’s City Council refused the proposal. Preston Group then appealed to the Local Planning Appeal Tribunal (LPAT), which has the power to overrule City Council, and gained their approval in 2019 [3]. After some negotiations between City Council and Preston Group, a modified plan was put forth. This plan includes the construction of two sets of townhouses and two condo buildings with thirty-seven and twelve storeys. In total, this would add over five hundred units to the property, which already houses a seventeen-storey apart-

ment building [4]. Preston Group did not respond to requests for a comment.

“When a development application is appealed to LPAT, there are unfortunately limited opportunities for the local community to participate, as residents must individually register to participate in the hearing. However, the City did meet their statutory obligation and beyond with this development application,” said City Councillor Denzil Minnan-Wong. He represents the Don Valley East region, Ward 16, which includes Flemingdon Park.

The North York Community Council, a subset of City Council, planned to hold a public meeting to discuss the Draft Plan of Subdivision Application for the building on 7 October 2020. This meeting was then rescheduled to 4 November 2020, as at the request of residents who felt there had been insufficient notice. According to the Tenant Association of the apartment building currently located at 25 St. Dennis Drive, none of the building’s tenants received notice of the original meeting [5]. Salwa spoke at the November meeting, asking the City not to approve the plan.

However, the majority of the

development had already been approved. “The Draft Plan of Subdivision is one of the last steps in the development approval process,” said Minnan-Wong. He also noted that “this was more of a technical approval as this development project was approved in principle in 2019.”

Residents of Flemingdon Park have raised several concerns with this proposal, primarily the destruction of green spaces and the further overcrowding of the neighbourhood. Sahar mentioned that over the summer, parents would take their children to the school parking lots to play, in an effort to maintain social distancing. “There was literally no space for people,” she said, “I don’t know about you, but I don’t think it’s normal to take your kids to a school parking lot because there’s no green space available.”

According to Toronto census data, Flemingdon Park has a population of over 21 000 residents and a population density of roughly 9 000 people per square metre [2]. This is more than double the average population density in Toronto, which is about 4300 people per square metre [6]. In a neighbourhood that is already densely populated, additional buildings would put a strain on the resources and services available. This can also lead to issues such as overcrowding on public transit and in the nearby public schools.

“If I take the [100 Flemingdon Park bus], there have been times in this pandemic when I’ve had to take the TTC. I might be in off-peak hours and the bus will still be crowded,” Sahar said. She also mentioned that Flemingdon Park had been reporting higher numbers of COVID cases, partially due to the lack of open space and lack of social distancing thereof.

Sahar also noted that the new developments will be made up of luxury units, which are far out of the price range of current Flemingdon residents: “the landlord is justifying this by claiming that they will keep the existing building affordable for twenty years. However, if you look at their current listings, rent for the apartment building ranges between \$1800-\$2000 per month, so around \$24 000 each year.” To put that into perspective, Toronto defines housing as affordable if it costs less than 30% of your household income [7]. According to census data, 75% of residents in the Flemingdon Park neighbourhood currently have an annual household income less than \$80 000, which is the minimum amount required in order for these apartments to be considered affordable. This pricing model raises concerns of gentrification in a community long held by tight-knit groups of intergenerational families.

“Considering the scale of this development, I fully understand the residents’ concerns about the impact it will have on the local community,” said Minnan-Wong. He also mentioned ways that Toronto is trying to address these concerns. This includes plans to build a school at the intersection of Don Mills Rd. and Eglinton Ave. East as well as the Eglinton Crosstown Light Rail Transit Line, which is scheduled to be completed in 2022.

Plans for development have already been approved by City Council, but Sahar and Saiwa hope they can halt the process if they receive enough responses to their petition. They initially began advertising for their petition outside local schools and put up posters in various apartment buildings. Another member of the community

created an Instagram post outlining how the development would negatively impact the community. The sisters have also been asking residents to fill out a Google Form to indicate that they had not received any information about the development or the consultation meeting with Preston Group.

On Friday, 20 November 2020, Sahar and Salwa sent a letter to Toronto City Council that included both the petition and the responses from the Google Form. Their goal was to convince City Council that the community consultations were inadequate. Their letter asks “that the vulnerable, neglected and already-marginalized Flemingdon Park residents be given due process and [be] properly consulted.”

If you are interested in viewing their petition, it can be found at the following link: https://www.change.org/p/toronto-city-council-save-flemingdon-park?utm_source=share_petition&utm_medium=custom_url&recruited_by_id=a8edbac0-22b1-11eb-a617-6f489efd5488

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LIFE BOARD

A board for imaginative self-expression through written and visual content.

Goodbye

by EMILY LAI

I don't understand why you left me here without saying goodbye.

You're gone forever and all I can do is gaze upon the grey skies that bear your name. Those grey skies mock me, cast upon my soul a shadow so deep that not even a black hole could suffocate the darkness within. It's like you single-handedly stole all the light I had carefully collected inside myself the moment you decided to walk away.

The grey streets, the grey subway station, the grey mist that hangs in the air, it is all lifeless, it is all gloomy, it is all calm. I want nothing more than to tear myself apart upon the bland concrete. Let my soul erupt and ignite the melancholy streets with sooty black and sapphire blue and burning red. Watch the world ripple into colour, my grief breaking free from its prison, the raging spirit I once buried now emerging from the catacombs. I wish this world, in its blandness, in its aching familiarity, could just stop for once on the railway tracks of life and watch me explode.

The twisted emotions grapple in their furnace, crackling anger and bubbling resentment swirling amidst the floating sorrow and fluttering pain. I feel the heat rising inside me, the deadly concoction ready to burst. The fiery glow blazes in the pit of my stomach.

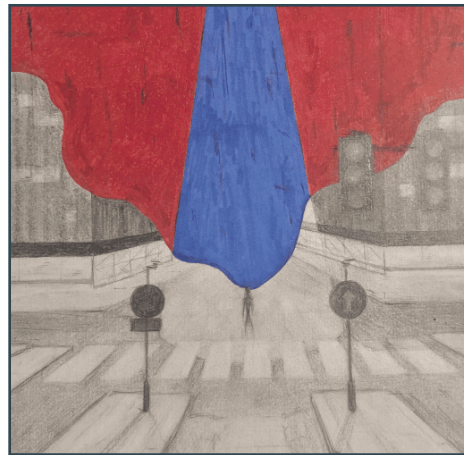


Illustration: COLLEEN CHANG

And then—
drip.

A cold droplet of rain sizzles against my burning skin
drip.

The water feels like ice against the warmth of my cheek
drip.

The gentle rain pulls me back down. The last of the sparks extinguish

I pull out my umbrella and brush off your gravestone one final time before I turn away.

drip. drip. drip.

The fire is gone, leaving nothing but a pile of ashes in my chest, the smoke tearing at my throat.

drip.

The sky is crying and so am I. ■

mastering baseball

by FATIMA SHARIPOVA

Let the sound play over and over again in your head.

(the *thump* a bat makes when it hits the ball)

If you listen closely, you'll hear it. Drown out the voices of people, mute the distant hum of traffic, pretend the sirens aren't there. You'll hear the thump thump thump of a bat knocking a ball, 80 times a minute, nonstop.

Trace it down roads of silent traffic to Wilson & Keele. Follow the echo to Humber River Hospital, where it's a matter of hitting the ball, not catching it. And in room 209, bed 5, is the source of the *thumping*.

It'll drive you crazy if you listen to the cough of tuberculous lungs and the statistics on why your son's unlikely to make it to twelve. But listen only to the thumps of perseverance and maybe you'll teach your own heart the rhythm to keep *thumping*. Just in case it ever forgets how. ■



Illustration: ZOE CHENG

Christmas Poem

by AMY JIA

Bright plush snowbanks,
and trees blanketed in white,
snowflakes drifting slowly down,
winter's cold clean sights,

brings fairy lights twinkling,
spiraling around trees,
shining gold, red, green, rainbow,
swaying in chilly breeze,

wishlists placed in envelopes,
with children's wants of the year,
to be sent to Santa soon,
who will deliver presents by reindeer,

present-hunts are on,
Christmas markets bustling and busy,
eyes scanning stalls and booths,
gifts bought and sold quickly,

carols sung by choirs,
or blasted on car radios,
about joy, love, winter holidays,
or Rudolph the reindeer's red nose,

scents of fresh brewed apple cider,
and warm baked gingerbread,
candy canes licked to sharp white points,
hungry mouths quickly fed,

neatly wrapped boxes and tight ribbons atop,
under the adorned green tree,
stockings filled with bulging treasures,
satisfied giggles of glee,

spirit and smiles and excitement everywhere,
Christmas's wonders returning,
prompting so much amity, bliss, and warmth,
that when it's over, we're left yearning!



Photograph: JESSICA XIONG

Photograph: BILL YAN



A Myriad of Realities
Maryam Mobashir



Crossroads
Sarah Li

Inner Demons

by JAVERIA SAJID

Like a shadow in an eternal night,
It does not let you go or let you live in the light.
Dragging you deeper into an endless tunnel.
Ensnaring you with chains,
Pumping venom into your veins.

The darkness tunnels its way in and rises inside me.
So I fall.
In tears, I wrap my arms around my knees
And rock my broken heart to sleep.

As thunder booms,
I smile.
It was the scream my mouth never made.
Lightning strikes, tearing the sky apart with a raging
crackle.
The anger is unleashed
And rain pours violently from the sky,
Battering against the broken shards of my heart.

The clouds release what my heart refused to.
They mourn for what I have lost.

Though the downpour lasts only minutes,
It is all I need to regain strength in my bones.

But, no matter how far I go,
They stay with me.
Nestled deep within the caverns of my soul,
My inner demons won't leave.

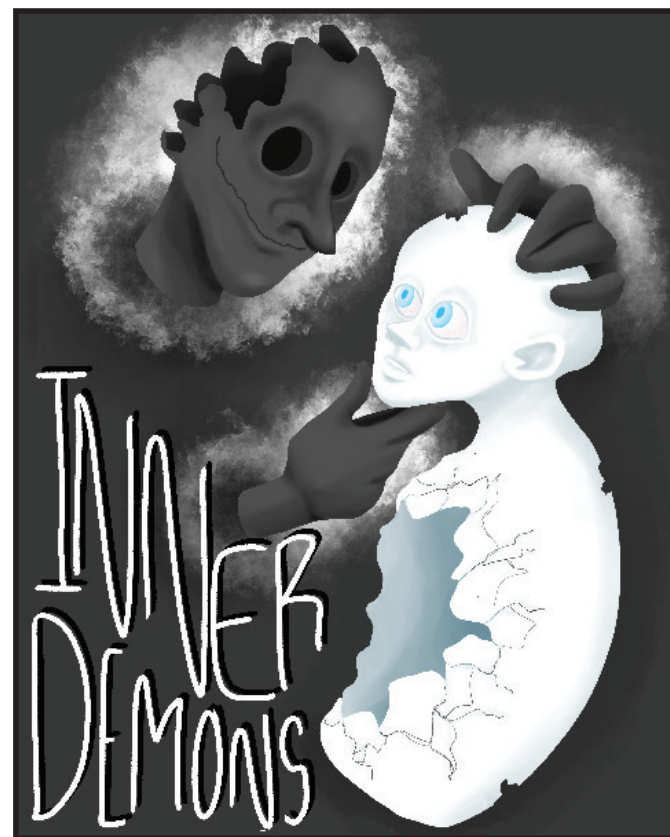


Illustration: Ajita Kanthathasan

fugue in f Minor (sei così bello sotto il sole dorato)

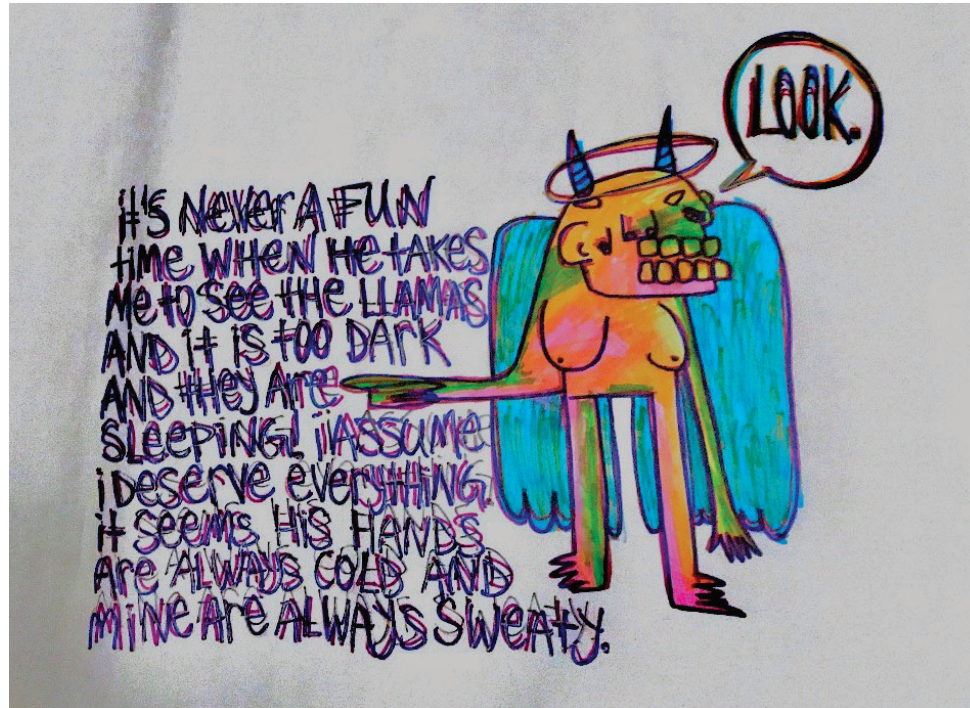
by RIVER WEI

You're fading,
fading, into the horizon;
slipping through his fingers like smoke that burns
and blisters
and he was a coward for not holding on tighter.
You're a falling angel
shoulder blades baring testimony of stripped
wings;
they bleed and, oh, they'll never stop bleeding,
the land where you lie rusted with chrysanthemums.
You, skin strewn with spiderweb cracks;
fragile china, not yet broken
a steel heart with a glass core:
that one careless touch could shatter you, destroy
you.
Do you believe in gravity—

that it can tear apart as much as it draws together?
What if I could save you?
We're two sides of a coin; we're life and death.
I love you:
I love the scars around your lips and throat that I
kissed so many times
like the remnants of lashes of fire;
your soul, anchored by grief: your shoulders,
heavy with burden.
I love every part of you,
and when the golden sun burns bright and brilliant
against the crimson heavens,
when the violet velvet night sky is no more,
I'll come back for you.



Photograph: Jessica Xiong



Making Out at the
Petting Zoo
India Das-Brown

ADVER- TISING SPACE

roselips
Lucy Qi



EDITORIAL BOARD

A board that amplifies student voices through supported opinions.

This Title Is Terrible, Just Like Early Christmas Celebrations

by CONNER LEE

It's the end of November and we have once again survived the plague of far-too-early Christmas traditions. Thankfully, with the pandemic, my eardrums weren't assaulted by "All I Want for Christmas is You" three times a day. However, this blessing only lasts for one year, and we must rid ourselves of this disease as soon as possible. To garner support towards peace and justice, I present you my indisputable, irrefutable, incontestable arguments on why all things Christmas should not exist until December.

Christmas music strikes fear within my heart, but for the sake of the festive mood I often endure it. However, if you're one of the people who play Christmas music during November, I have some bad news for you—you're trapped in a cult. Give me a chance to explain myself, then you can decide whether or not to throw me in a pot of boiling water. "He sees you when you're sleeping, he knows when you're awake." These words should send a chill down your spine, but the influence of Christmas music made them something acceptable for children to sing and believe in. We are

taught from a young age that Santa knows everything we do, and only well-behaved children will receive rewards in the form of presents. Santa is, in essence, viewed as an all-knowing god. There's just a small problem, he's pretty much the opposite of that. Santa violates the privacy of millions of children, breaks into the homes of billions of people, violates workers rights by giving his elves zero pay and benefits, and the list goes on.

The scary thing is, there's zero accountability for his actions. In fact, the legal system has been lulled into a state of sloth and in-

action when against Santa Claus, believing it is futile to oppose a figure with such power and wealth. When we put all the evidence together, the dreadful truth reveals itself — the world has become accustomed to Santa's abuse of power. How else can we explain our infatuation towards this man, who should be put behind bars for his heinous crimes but is instead celebrated annually?

I know what you're thinking: Santa is a terrible role model and all, but how can us mortals prosecute somebody revered as almost a god? Well, even if we don't have the

power to punish Santa, we can always start simple and lock up cultists who listen to Christmas music before December rolls around. Think about what emotions Christmas music tries to evoke. From songs we sing as children such as "Merry Christmas", "Frosty the Snowman", to pop music such as "Mistletoe" and "Let it Snow", they all attempt to evoke a feeling of happiness! I have every right to dress in black, be depressed, and grumble all day long during the holiday season, but to remain socially acceptable I am coerced into acting joyful, dressing in vibrant colors, and enjoying Christmas music. Telling people how to act, think, and feel is a defining characteristic of cults, and Christmas cheer fits the mold perfectly. Dressing up, listening to specific music, and performing the same acts to worship their god, Santa. If that isn't a cultist ritual, I don't know what is.

Eliminating these cultists dismantles unrealistic expectations that one must be happy even before the holiday arrives, and destabilizes Santa's Reign of Terror so one day, maybe, just maybe, we can end the rule of this tyrant.

If you're a stubborn goat who wasn't convinced by my flawless argument, I've got one more: Christmas brings a myriad of safety hazards, namely, the alarming presence of candy canes. You heard me right, I'm referring to those sticks of diabetes kids love to eat. A hidden danger lies within these innocent-looking candies when you suck on one for too long - its tip becomes perilously sharp.

There are those who maliciously use candy canes as dangerous weapons, and it's been shown that candy cane stabbings increase by 123.456% during November [1]. Potential criminals take advantage of the fact that they are on sale at every Walmart without mental health or permit checks.

These canes are then sold and distributed across the black market, making their origins impossible to track. Although the dangers of candy canes are crystal clear, the Candian government refuses to take action because of the corporate lobbying from "Santa's elves against people who are against November celebrations." Candy canes in November are a leading cause of violent crimes in modern society and with current technology and policies, it is impossible to regulate them. With the fragile state of our society, it is imperative to push through corporate lobbying and ban these arms to make our world a safer place to live in. You might ask: why does the Candy Cane Crisis resolve itself in December? The answer is quite simple: in December everybody has access to candy canes, allowing everybody to defend and protect themselves. It is common knowledge that everybody should keep a candy cane in their bedroom drawer as well as their pocket at all times. This improves safety drastically, in the same way that America is the safest place in the world thanks to the glorious Second Amendment. If we attempt to ban candy canes at this time, it will become impossible for citizens to protect themselves and criminals will run rampant.

Early Christmas is a recipe for the worship of Santa, cult rituals, and candy cane stabbings. In other words, disaster. However, it's not too late to fight back. Visit www.change.org/p/santa-delete-christmas-music-during-november to make your voice heard escape from this hell. With your help, we can make November a safer time for all of us. ■

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You Would Look Hotter Bald

by VICKY WEN

You read the title correctly, and everyone, including you dear reader, should go bald at least once in their life. Especially now, during the quarantines. Who's going to judge you for being bald, your cat?

First, it's the perfect opportunity to try out every single hairstyle you've ever wanted to try. Now, I know that sounds counterintuitive (a distinct lack of hair may be a cause for concern when you wanted curtain bangs) but I promise it'll make sense. If you know that you're going to shave off all of your hair on a set date, then the day before is when you get to have the most fun with a pair of scissors. Bangs, a mullet, a mohawk if you're feeling frisky, they're all on the table! You get to test out everything you want to try, with no fear of repercussions the day after.

It is literally the epitome of a fresh start. If you've been excessively bleaching, trimming and otherwise damaging your hair, now is a great time to rejuvenate it. All those split ends, broken strands, knots? Completely gone. Don't you miss people complimenting you on how soft your hair is? Don't you want your hair to match your eyebrows? Also, you'll get to see your natural hair texture. Buzzing your hair off is a fast and easy way to get rid of those problems. Plus, it feels amazing when you or someone else touches your head. It allows you to get rid of a lot of distractors—such as spending several hours bleaching and dye-



Illustration: Elizabeth Wei

ing your hair—and allows you to really spend time introspectively and get to know yourself.

If a fresh start and getting to try out different hairstyles aren't enough to convince you, this will. You'll be twinning with Mr. Clean, possibly one of the most powerful beings to exist. On a serious note though, being bald makes your features pop. Your face is usually partially covered by your hair and by having it bare, you may notice that certain parts of your face become more prominent. For example, your ears are more present. This can make it easier for you to play around with earrings, for example, or make-up, as it's more noticeable. Also, change your clothes. You can play with so many different silhouettes now that you're freshly bald.

Moreover, you'll be saving so much time and money! Who doesn't want to save time and money? Washing your hair will take five minutes compared to the twenty minutes it would take to shampoo and condition. The fifteen minute difference over time is something you can do so much with: learn a new language, learn how to make focaccia, so many opportunities to choose from. You're going to be saving money by using barely any hair products; shampoo, conditioner, heat protectant? Nonexistent. Just as important, you won't have to worry about brushing your hair, getting your hair caught in stuff, feeling your hair on your neck—it's a game changer.

Finally, you will look absolutely amazing. Hotter even. People with buzz cuts are just cooler in my opinion. It's a great conversation starter, and lots of people will want to know about it. It's a great opportunity to raise awareness about hair loss related to chemotherapy and alopecia. It's basically the less intense version of



Illustration: Max Lu

getting pregnant and seeing how many friends you have left. Buzzing your hair off can be empowering, fun, and a choice that you will remember fondly down the road.

However, there are some things to keep in mind if you're planning on doing a big chop. Shaving off your hair should be first and foremost centred around your wants and needs. You have to be prepared for other people's judgments and criticisms, not accept them, but be aware that they will hold them. A lot of people are uncomfortable with people that don't conform to what they view as socially acceptable and will voice their unsolicited opinions

and concerns. You might have people asking you if you are mentally stable. This question unfortunately is more often asked of feminine presenting people rather than masculine people. People might also ask you if you have cancer or another illness that caused you to lose your hair. People will stare at you, in stores, in school and at other places.

But, overall I think the benefits outweigh the risks and I'm really glad that I shaved my head. You don't ever need a reason to shave your hair and you don't owe people explanations either. Hair grows back, and beauty is subjective anyway. Go bald! ■

Déjà Vu: A Tale of French Discrimination

by MARYAM MOBASHIR, UROOBA SHAIKH, and SUNYAH TEHREEM

Muslims today know the drill: if a person happens to identify with Islam and is responsible for a major disturbance, news outlets will plaster the word “terrorist” all over headlines. The events of the past week which resulted in the beheading of a teacher in France were no different, and once again Islam is under fire. In addition, French President Emmanuel Macron's comments have led to an escalation of the situation and encouraged western media to ramp up the negative portrayal of Islam.

France has a long history of Islamophobia disguised as secularism. It began with the onset of the secularism policy in 2004 which prohibits the wearing of all conspicuous religious items in all government-operated public spaces, namely schools and workplaces [1]. The policy targeted Muslim women and Sikh men as the largest demographic of people who display a religious symbol. Another example of this is the burkini ban that was put into place in fifteen cities in 2016. Many Muslim women observe some form of modesty in the way they dress, and a burkini is a garment meant to allow water activities while upholding this modesty. During the summer of 2016, there were numerous cases of police officers forcing women to remove items of clothing while they were on the beach. Police issued tickets stating that the women were not wearing “an outfit respecting good morals and secularism” [2]. The mayor of Nice, one of the cities in which the ban was implemented, stated that the measure was “necessary to protect the population” [2]. It is unclear what protection the population needs from a full-sleeved tunic with a hood.

Many politicians who support secularism have been outright Islamophobic with comments that promote the tormenting and insulting of Muslims. For example, Laurent Bouvet, a political science professor appointed to the

Council of Elders of Secularism by the education minister recently tweeted a photo saying “I got the masks”, showing bacon slices folded in a mask shape, attempting to mock Muslims and their restraint from pork [3]. A government official mocking the dietary restrictions of a religion promotes stigma surrounding this religion and makes many Muslims feel like the targets of mockery.

France has often taken a collective punishment attitude towards Muslims. French politicians have had a long history of making irresponsible remarks about Islam, especially following individual attacks, which in turn has caused many French citizens to interpret the whole religion negatively. In 2015, the French government displayed their biased views when they instituted a state of emergency in response to the Charlie Hebdo attacks which saw 12 people dead [4]. This gave the police the power to perform arrests and warrantless searches in an attempt to free France from extremist networks. Unfortunately, this led to the targeting of the Muslim community and resulted in the unwarranted arrests of many innocent Muslims based solely on conjecture and prejudice. The police carried out approximately 3 600 warrantless searches and arrests, which resulted in only six cases that lead to terrorism-related criminal investigations [4]. It is noted that society treats crimes committed by people of other or no faith differently in comparison to how they treat Muslim perpetrators. There is no uproar from the general public against other religions as a whole when a follower of that religion commits a religiously-motivated crime. Neither does the government take special action to deal with the threat supposedly posed by members of these religious communities. Each part of an individual's identity should not be deconstructed and bashed by their own government to the point where oth-

er members of their community don't feel safe simply due to their identity.

In terms of the most recent events, Samuel Paty, a middle school teacher in France had shown his class, which consisted of Muslim students, naked caricatures of the Prophet Muhammad. He did so during a lesson on freedom of expression. Paty faced criticism for his actions from parents of students in his class, and he was killed on October 21st by Abdoullakh Anzorov, an 18-year-old Russian refugee.

In an official statement following the incident, Macron said regarding Samuel Paty; “he was killed because the Islamists want our future. They know that with quiet heroes like him, they will never have it” [5]. Yes, the person should never have killed or even harmed the teacher. Likewise, no one should fear violence because of their differing views. Muslims in France and around the world have condemned the killing of the teacher, however, Macron portraying the teacher as a hero and Islam as the villain is not the right course of action. Firstly, it is deeply offensive in Islam to visually depict the Prophet, even in a complimentary way, so as not to promote idol worship. The teacher had said for Muslim students to leave the classroom if they felt like the caricatures would offend them which shows that he was aware of the implications of his actions.

Muslims are the biggest minority group in France comprising about nine percent of France's population [6]. Policies, politicians, media, and individuals have all alienated Muslims and made them feel as though society does not accept them and that they should change themselves in order to completely assimilate. The gradual portrayal of the message that Muslims are the other and that there is no room for Islam in a secular French society has made many of them feel like they can



Illustration: Emily Lai

never truly be both Muslim and French.

The Muslims of France in particular have experienced extreme alienation in the wake of the attack. Following Macron's comments, two European women stabbed two hijab-wearing women under the Eiffel Tower on October 21 shouting racial slurs like "dirty Arabs" and "go back to where you came from" [4]. A few days later, two people severely beat a Jordanian man and his sister after hearing them speaking Arabic [7]. These incidents are some of the most blatant cases of Islamophobia following the attack, but it has also resulted in the closing of mosques, instances of hijabs being ripped off women's heads, and French media airing more

anti-Muslim content [8]. Macron said, "Islam is a religion in crisis all over the world. Our citizens are waiting for us to act. The government has launched dozens of operations against associations, and also individuals who support a plan of radical Islamism, in other words, an ideology to destroy the (French) Republic" [5]. While Macron's intentions of reducing terrorism may be well-intentioned, his statements, as well as his approach, are causing tensions to rise among the French population and around the world.

Prime Minister Justin Trudeau responded to the situation in France by first and foremost condemning the actions of the person that behaved unac-

ceptably. He then went on to say that, "In a pluralistic, diverse and respectful society like ours, we must be aware of the impact of our words, of our actions on others, particularly these communities and populations who still experience enormous discrimination. We owe it to ourselves to act with respect for others and to seek not to arbitrarily or unnecessarily injure those with whom we are sharing a society and a planet" [9].

Trudeau's statement was met with anger from people who felt as though Trudeau had not "absolutely" denounced terrorism [9]. However, what Trudeau said was not an acceptance of the violent actions of some people, but an important reminder that freedom of speech has its limits, and that people should never use it to disgrace and alienate a group of people. Respect is of utmost importance, and when something is found to be legitimately offensive to some people, then the human thing to do would be to apologize and not justify those actions.

While national security is definitely an important factor in the decisions and laws a country and its political leaders make, vilifying Muslims and further marginalizing them is unacceptable. Macron and his government need to realize that the violent actions of a very small group of people should not result in laws that alienate a whole group of innocent people. National security does not justify careless remarks made by a political leader that demonize a group of people who are not blameworthy of the actions of people who happen to be of the same religion. It's overdue now that Macron and his government show support for the Muslim community, and realize that they are also just as affected by terrorism. Islamophobia should have no place in the laws of any country. It's about time that the French government stop cowering behind the finger they point at Muslims, and instead, work to actually solve the problem on hand which has absolutely nothing to do with Islam, and everything to do with the person or organization who committed the crime and them alone. Dear French government, Islam does not equal terrorism. ■

The Board That Failed Toronto Students

by ANNE LIU and
EDWARD YANG

The Toronto District School Board was not at all prepared for what was coming alongside the COVID-19 pandemic. The board, with 247 000 students on the line, has failed to provide an acceptable system regarding all aspects of online school [1].

The TDSB had the full summer break to prepare for the new hybrid school system, not to mention the several months in hiatus after the pandemic hit. They were well aware that the pandemic would force hundreds of thousands of students to move to the online school platform. Yet with that knowledge in mind, there was still an incredible lack of foresight and effort put into this matter, leaving students and parents all across the board confused and frustrated. This school year, 18 000 high school students initially chose the virtual learning format, and hundreds more are still trying to transfer from in-person to virtual school [2]. Considering just how many families have chosen the virtual format and the foresight that many would go online when the second wave hit as predicted, it was expected of the board to provide students with, at the very least, an acceptable platform with proper teaching, working apps, and accommodations to specialized programs like art programs, International Baccalaureate, TOPS, etc. How many of those expectations were fulfilled? None, and it's laughable.

So, the TDSB has failed to provide students with a working virtual platform. They scrambled to get enough teachers, disregarded specialized programs, and failed to organize required systems, such as how teachers would communicate with their students. What else have they done? Did it occur to them that students would need technology to engage in such



Illustration: Akshaya Varakunan

virtual platforms? The shortsighted fact is that the TDSB had the funds to distribute laptops and set them up. The TDSB gave out over \$2 million of raises to principals for doing extra work during the summer [3], yet almost 2 000 students are currently still waiting to receive laptops and tablets for virtual learning [4]. The budget of the TDSB for this school year is \$3.4 billion, and while around \$3.2 is used to pay for salaries [5], there are approximately \$200 million left. The Dell Chromebook 3189, which is widely suited for school, costs \$330 [6]. Multiply that by 2 000 students, and only \$660 000 are needed, a small percentage of the total budget that is key to keeping schools safe. Instead of the 2 million dollars in raises to principals, they could have used \$660 000 of it so that students can learn safely at home.

After all this chaos, one might think that they'd take the blame upon themselves and work to create a better system. After not being able to take the burden of managing students in the virtual school (lack of teachers, not enough resources, too many students, etc.) the board forced the load onto the individual schools themselves to accommodate students wanting to switch to virtual school. So on top of complicating things for students, parents, and teachers, they revoked their plan of action and brought it onto those struggling principals and teachers, who had to quickly organize everything in the

school to accommodate these learners.

The TDSB's excuse was that the centralized virtual school system wasn't able to handle these students. As a school board, it is your responsibility to adapt your system to the number of students. It is your responsibility to make sure students are provided with an education. And it is your responsibility to provide resources and planned strategies so that students are able to learn. While one may argue that it is part of a school's responsibility to accommodate students' needs, it is the TDSB's duty to provide sufficient resources and work with individual schools to formulate plans in order to acclimatize to all these students. The TDSB "is telling brick and mortar principals they'll have to determine how to accommodate students wishing to switch to online learning" [2], meaning they provided little to no guidance for schools and left them to determine for themselves how to help these students.

What did we expect coming into this strange school year? A perfect fully functioning utterly faultless school system? Certainly not. But we expected the very least anyone could expect from a school board: we expected to be cared for, our problems heard, and a working virtual system that would allow students to work effectively. We expected the very least from the TDSB. We set our standard on the ground. The board dug a hole. ■

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